the task of using evidence from mobile phones and other high-tech devices ‘easier’ for the prosecution. In other words, bring back or make laws that enable phone tapping and surveillance on a generalized scale, that facilitate the faulty transcription and translation of tapped conversations, that enable the manipulation or obfuscation of phone records, and that do not have to produce the taped evidence in court in order to obtain a necessary conviction, and that enable the airing and unofficial pre-censoring of ‘interviews’ of the accused in detention in the media while a trial is in process, so that television network news executives can have an easier night’s sleep and count their takings.

In a remarkable admission, while playing once again the ‘dramatization’ of Afzal’s indoctrination (once again from the ‘13 December’ film) the Zee News broadcast commentator said in passing what was to the effect—‘Afzal was a surrendered militant, he had worked off and on for the STF for seven years, and he had met Tariq in an STF camp in Dral.’ Why was this piece of information which had been available in the court records, like everything else in this case, since 21 September 2002, not made public knowledge either in the previous Zee News programmes, or in any programmes thereafter to inform the public? Any reasonable person would surmise that a person who has been in regular contact with intelligence operatives of the Indian state, who has been harassed by them, who has had money extorted by them (as per his wife’s statement made to a newspaper), must also be asked what relationships these operatives had to the sequence of events leading up to 13 December. If one needle of suspicion points at ‘militants’ and their handlers, whether local or across the border, then, clearly, another ‘needle of suspicion’ (which looks stronger, at least, circumstantially) also points to the activities and personnel of the shadowy agency or cluster of agencies called the ‘Special Task Force’. Until these details are investigated, we cannot come to any certain conclusion about who Afzal is, what role he played, and why he has to die.

Why also were the surveillance camera footage of the vehicle seen proceeding towards the Parliament building about as far as the ‘Red Cross Road–Sansad Marg’ roundabout not ever made public before? Was it because the channel had to ‘wait’ until the case was satisfactorily ‘closed’? Surely any journalist or television producer would know that the vicinity of the Parliament and other sensitive government buildings have been photographed on CCTV cameras for a long time. Surely an analysis of the movement of the